Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Zechariah

Zechariah 1:1

- This introduction labels the book of Zechariah as an oracle, which means it is an authoritative message inspired by God. The prophet Zechariah served as God's messenger, chosen to speak with God's authority.
- King Darius ruled from 521 to 486 BC, during the early years of the Persian Empire. The Persian Empire ruled a large part of the ancient world from 539 to 331 BC.

Zechariah 1:1–6

The prelude identifies the book's themes as repentance and spiritual renewal, and establishes a tone of hope and encouragement.

Zechariah 1:3

- the LORD of Hosts: God has an infinite number of angelic troops ready to do his will (see 2 Kings 6:17; Matthew 26:53). The phrase was probably meant to be an encouragement to the Judeans.
- Return to me: Repentance means a complete change. It is a move away from sin and self towards loyalty to God and his covenant (see Isaiah 44:22; Malachi 3:7; see also Psalms 80:3–14; 85:4–8).

Zechariah 1:4

- Before the exile in Babylon, earlier prophets urged Judah and Israel to repent. Zechariah shows the influence of Jeremiah and Ezekiel.
- your fathers ... they did not listen: The people of Israel (2 Kings 17:13–14) and Judah (2 Chronicles 36:15–16) went into exile because they stubbornly ignored the word of the Lord (compare 2 Chronicles 30:7).

Zechariah 1:6

did not My words ... overtake your fathers?: The covenant curses described in Deuteronomy 28:15–68 had come upon their ancestors because they refused to obey God.

Zechariah 1:7–17

Zechariah's first vision shows God's concern for Jerusalem (Zechariah 1:7–15). This is followed by a response (Zechariah 1:16–17) that confirms God's plans to rebuild the temple and restore the city's prosperity.

Zechariah 1:7–6.15

These eight visions helped the Judeans overcome their fears and trust in God's promises. The visions happened two months after Haggai's last two messages (Haggai 2:10–19, 20–23). They suggest that Haggai's prophecies were coming true.

Zechariah 1:8

- The vision during the night follows a standard pattern:
- an introductory statement,
- a description of the vision,
- the prophet's request for an interpretation, and
- an angelic explanation.
- The myrtle trees were likely in the wooded Kidron Valley outside Jerusalem. The Lord had symbolically returned to the edge of the city. He had not yet entered Jerusalem because the temple was still being rebuilt.
- The colors of the red, brown, and white horses are not important to this vision's meaning. These angelic riders patrolled the earth (Zechariah 1:10), showing God's ongoing concern for Jerusalem.

Zechariah 1:10

Patrol suggests the angelic riders continuously watch over the earth.

Zechariah 1:11

The man on a red horse among the myrtle trees (Zechariah 1:8) is referred to as the angel of the Lord (compare Genesis 16:7–13; Exodus 23:23; 32:34; Judges 13:21–22).

Zechariah 1:14

I am very jealous: This phrase shows intense devotion. It can lead to hatred and envy or zeal and dedication. God is jealous because, as the one true and living God, he has exclusive rights to his creatures' worship (see Exodus 20:5; 34:14).

Jerusalem represents the areas ruled by Judean kings, and Mount Zion was where the Lord's temple stood.

Zechariah 1:17

The word again appears four times in Hebrew to stress God's definite plan to restore Jerusalem.

Zechariah 1:18–19

- Then I looked up suggests the prophet was interrupted by another vision while still focused on the previous one (also in Zechariah 2:1; 5:1; 6:1).
- Horns symbolized power and authority in the biblical world and might represent an individual ruler (see Daniel 7:8; 8:8), a family line of kings, or nations.

Zechariah 1:18–21

The second vision reveals God's plan to judge the nations that destroyed Jerusalem and exiled Judah. The prophet does not specify which nations the four horns represent. It is best to see the number four as a symbol for all nations that will face divine judgment for scattering God's people.

Zechariah 1:20

The word translated as blacksmiths could refer to any type of craftsman, such as a mason, carpenter, or smith. If the horns representing the nations were metal (see 1 Kings 22:11), then blacksmiths were suitable for the task of destroying them (see 2 Chronicles 24:12; Isaiah 44:12).

Zechariah 1:21

- scattered Judah: They literally raised their horns against Judah.
- The Lord would cut off those horns, throw them to the ground, and end their authority. The Judeans did not need to fear the nearby nations.

Zechariah 2:1–5

The visions move from a wide focus to a narrow one. They begin with the whole world (vision 1), then move to the nations (vision 2), and finally focus on the city of Jerusalem. The vision itself appears in 2:1–3, followed by an explanation of its meaning in 2:4–5.

Zechariah 2:2

determine its width and length: By taking this measurement, God showed he was planning for Jerusalem's future.

Zechariah 2:5

- The wall of fire symbolizes divine protection (compare 2 Kings 6:17).
- I will be: The strong form of the verb to be emphasizes God's personal presence. It may point to God's name revealed to Moses (Exodus 3:14–15).
- Fire and glory point back to the Exodus, when God showed his presence through fire and glory (see Exodus 13:22; 14:20; 40:34).

Zechariah 2:6

- Get up!: This strong command promises that the Lord will lead his people out of exile and into a restored Jerusalem (compare Isaiah 55:1).
- the land of the north: Travelers had to go north to then move east, so people thought of Babylonia as being in the north.
- four winds: Hebrew exiles would return to Judah and Jerusalem from all directions (see Ezekiel 12:14; 37:9).

Zechariah 2:6–13

God called the exiles to return from Babylon, which predicted their return to Israel (Zechariah 2:6–9) and God's presence returning to Jerusalem (2:10–13).

Zechariah 2:8

whoever touches you touches the apple of His eye: This could refer to Israel as God's chosen people. It might also mean that those who harmed Israel hurt themselves by bringing God's judgment upon them.

Zechariah 2:9

they will become plunder for their own servant: During the exodus, the Egyptians gave the Israelites valuables to encourage them to leave (see Exodus 11:2–3; 12:35–36).

Zechariah 2:12

- Israel is the Lord's inheritance or special possession. The people of Israel belong to the Lord (Deuteronomy 32:9–10).
- The land is holy because of God's glorious presence in the Jerusalem temple (see Psalms 11:4; 15:1).

Zechariah 2:13

Be silent: The force of the Hebrew word (has) is like the English word "hush" (see Habakkuk 2:20; Zephaniah 1:7). This command calls for quiet respect in God's presence.

Zechariah 3:1

- Jeshua was the high priest and the religious leader among those who returned to Judah from exile in Babylon (Ezra 2:2). Jeshua worked with Zerubbabel, the governor of the restored community. They worked together to rebuild the temple in Jerusalem (Ezra 5:2; Haggai 2:1–5).

- Satan (literally The satan) is a member of the heavenly court. His role is to bring charges against human beings for wrongdoing. He speaks against them before God (see Job 1:6).

This adversarial role could be carried out by either human or divine beings (see Numbers 22:22; 1 Samuel 29:4; 1 Chronicles 21:1).
By New Testament times, Satan had become a personal name. It referred to the ruler of demons and the chief opponent of God's work (Mark 3:22; 2 Corinthians 4:4; Ephesians 6:11; Revelation 20:2).
- Satan's authority in the heavenly court is shown by his position at the angel's right hand.

Zechariah 3:1–10

The prophet's vision shows a heavenly court scene. Satan accuses Jeshua the high priest and claims that he is not fit to serve in his priestly role.

Zechariah 3:2–3

- The Lord takes both roles in the vision. He speaks in defense of Jeshua and also gives the final decision. He rejects the accusations, ends the case, and declares Jeshua innocent because God has chosen and cleansed him.
- Like a burning stick snatched from the fire, God saved Jeshua and other Hebrew exiles from near destruction in Babylon.
- Jeshua's filthy clothes symbolize the guilt and pollution of sin that led to the divine judgment of exile (Zechariah 3:4). Satan's accusations likely suggested that, just as an unclean priest was unfit for temple service, the Hebrews were unfit to be God's chosen people.

Zechariah 3:4

Take off his filthy clothes!: This action shows that God removes sin and guilt from Jeshua and from the Hebrew people. Through God's cleansing, they are restored to their former place before him.

Zechariah 3:5

The high priest's turban had a gold medallion with the words HOLY TO THE LORD (Exodus 28:36–38; see also study note on Zechariah 14:20). Placing a clean turban on Jeshua's head showed that God restored him to his role as priest and mediator for the people.

Zechariah 3:6–7

Restoration depended on obeying God (see also Deuteronomy 30:19–20).

Zechariah 3:8

- The high priest Jeshua and the other priests symbolized greater truths.
- Servant and Branch are both titles for the Messiah, God's chosen one (Isaiah 42:1; 53:2; Jeremiah 23:5; 33:15). As a servant, the Messiah follows God's will by becoming a sin offering so that many can become righteous (Isaiah 53:11; see Acts 3:13; 4:27). The Branch is a metaphor for kingship, showing the Messiah as a descendant of David (Isaiah 11:1; Jeremiah 23:5).

Zechariah 3:9

- The stone represents authority. It may refer to the last stone of the temple placed by Zerubbabel (Zechariah 4:7), the cornerstone of the rebuilt Jerusalem (Isaiah 28:16), or the precious stones on the high priests' ephod (Exodus 25:7; 35:9).
- The seven parts (seven eyes) of the stone suggest perfect and complete knowledge and wisdom. They might connect to the seven lamps of the golden lampstand (Zechariah 4:2) or to God's seven spirits (Revelation 1:4).
- The inscription recalls the names of the tribes engraved on the high priest's shoulder-pieces (Exodus 39:6).
- The removal of Israel's sin in one day refers to the day of atonement (Leviticus 16). It points ahead to the death of Jesus on the cross, when the Lamb of God would take away the sin of the world (John 1:29).

Zechariah 3:10

On that day: This phrase refers to the day of the Lord (see Zechariah 2:11; Isaiah 2:11; Joel 2:1; Zephaniah 1:14). It is the day when God intervenes in history to judge the wicked, save the righteous, and restore creation (see Zechariah 12:8; 14:3–4).

Zechariah 4:1

woke me: Zechariah received a series of visions (Zechariah 1:7–6:8) in one night. The prophet slept briefly before this fifth vision.

Zechariah 4:1–14

This vision shows that God, through his Spirit, would help Zerubbabel and Jeshua rebuild the temple.

Zechariah 4:2–3

- gold lampstand: The golden menorah in the Tabernacle was first described in Exodus 25:31. A similar lampstand was later placed in the new temple. It

served as a symbol of God's purity and holiness and of the light that comes from his revelation.
- The two olive trees represent the roles of priest and king in Israel. They symbolize Jeshua and Zerubbabel. The golden oil represents God's Holy Spirit (see also Zechariah 4:12–14).

Zechariah 4:6

Jeshua and Zerubbabel would succeed in rebuilding the temple in Jerusalem, not by their own power, but because of God's empowering Spirit (compare Haggai 2:4–5).

Zechariah 4:7

- O great mountain ... become a plain: This phrase is a metaphor used in both the Old Testament (see Isaiah 40:4; 49:11) and the New Testament (see Matthew 17:20; 1 Corinthians 13:2). It means that faith in God helps people overcome difficult challenges.
- The capstone or headstone, which is the final stone, completes a stone wall or building (see Psalm 118:22).
- Grace, grace to it! is a prayer asking for God's favor and blessing on the new temple.

Zechariah 4:10

- A plumb line is a cord with a tin or lead weight at one end. It helps ensure a wall is vertical in construction.
- these seven eyes: Seven represents completeness or perfection. God observes everything on earth and controls the destinies of people and nations.

Zechariah 4:14

two anointed ones: Jeshua and Zerubbabel, served as the religious and civic leaders of Jerusalem after the return from exile in Babylon (Zechariah 3:1, 7; 4:6–7; Haggai 1:14; 2:2–3). They were anointed with oil during their commissioning. Under their leadership, the temple of the Lord was rebuilt, and worship was restored in Jerusalem.

Zechariah 5:1

- Again I lifted up my eyes: This is the sixth of eight visions Zechariah had in one night.
- A scroll, similar to a book in biblical times, was usually made of rolled parchment or leather, but sometimes of papyrus, tin, or copper. This scroll was flying, unfurled like a banner for everyone to see.

Zechariah 5:1–4

Zechariah's vision of the flying scroll reminded the leaders and people of Judah after the exile that they still had to follow God's commands. The blessings and curses of the law still applied (see Deuteronomy 28).

Zechariah 5:3

curse (or oath): A covenant included punishments for those who broke the agreement (see Deuteronomy 29:12–21).

Zechariah 5:4

This curse acts like a law officer to punish those who break God's covenant (see Psalm 147:15; Isaiah 55:11).

Zechariah 5:5–11

The seventh vision continues the theme of cleansing that began when the high priest Jeshua was declared innocent (Zechariah 3:1–10). The removal of wickedness, like the removal of Jeshua's filthy clothes (Zechariah 3:4), shows God's gracious forgiveness. This act comes from the covenant-keeping God.

Zechariah 5:6

The measuring basket, known as an ephah in Hebrew, was a standard unit for measuring dry goods. An ephah was about half a bushel. Old Testament prophets condemned unfair ephahs. They associated the ephah basket with wrongdoing (see Ezekiel 45:10; Micah 6:10).

Zechariah 5:7

The heavy lead cover weighed about 34 kilograms (75 pounds), which is one talent. This was not a normal cover for an ephah basket. Its weight shows that special action was needed to seal the basket's unholy contents.

Zechariah 5:7–8

a woman sitting inside the basket: This symbolizes a tempting and dangerous force that is hard to control. The sin of worshiping idols had earlier caused God's judgment (2 Kings 17:16–18; 2 Chronicles 36:14).

Zechariah 5:8

Wickedness can be moral evil or ceremonial evil, and it is opposed to righteousness (see Proverbs 13:6; Ezekiel 33:12). The word wickedness (Hebrew rish'ah) sounds similar in Hebrew to the name Asherah, the fertility goddess of the ancient Near East (see Deuteronomy 7:5; 16:21).

Zechariah 5:9

In the Old Testament, it is rare to see divine or angelic winged creatures depicted as women. If these two women are the Lord's servants, they are unique angels. If they serve Wickedness (a foreign goddess), their obedience to God's command shows his power over false gods.

Zechariah 5:11

- Idolatry (the worship of idols) is a powerful and aggressive form of evil. It cannot be contained among God's people. God orders it to be removed and sent back to its place of origin, Babylonia.

This image shows that God is able to remove every form of wickedness that separates his people from him.

- The land of Babylonia was where the Hebrews were held captive (Micah 4:10). The prophets describe it as wicked and idolatrous (Isaiah 46–47; Jeremiah 50–51).

In the New Testament, Babylon represents the evil Roman Empire (Revelation 17:5; 18:2; see 1 Peter 5:13).

Zechariah 6:1

- Chariots represent the quick and decisive power of God's intervention in human affairs.
- The two bronze mountains are enhanced images of the two bronze pillars that once stood at the entrance to Solomon's temple (1 Kings 7:13–22). Bronze symbolizes the unbreakable strength of God's dwelling.

Zechariah 6:1–8

In Zechariah's first and last visions, God sends horses to patrol the earth. These visions demonstrate God's control and care for all nations. This is an important part of Zechariah's message of comfort and encouragement to the people of Judah after their exile in Babylon.

Zechariah 6:2–3

red … black … white … dappled horses: Zechariah does not give special meaning to the horse colors in his vision (compare Revelation 6:1–8).

Zechariah 6:5

The four spirits (or the four winds) are members of a divine council. They report to God after their missions to the four directions of the earth (see Zechariah 2:6). God rules over the entire world. The teams of chariot horses carry out God's judgment.

Zechariah 6:7

The teams of horses appear strong and eager to do the Lord's work (Zechariah 6:5). They move only when the Lord commands.

Zechariah 6:8

- the LORD summoned me: The series of visions ends with a direct message from the Lord to Zechariah. By bypassing the interpreting angel, God stresses the certain and effective fulfillment of his word to Israel.
- have given rest to My Spirit: Spirit can mean "anger," as it does here (see Judges 8:3; Isaiah 33:11).

Zechariah 6:9–15

This important message comes with Zechariah's eighth vision (Zechariah 6:1–8). Jeshua's symbolic crowning as both king and priest was not a real political setup for Judah. It likely represents the coming of the Messiah, God's chosen king.

In Zechariah, the Branch is a title for this coming Messiah. The image describes new growth from what seemed dead, like a shoot growing from a cut-down tree. This shows that, even after exile and failure, God will raise up a new ruler from David's line. The Branch will build the temple of the Lord and unite kingship and priesthood in one person (Zechariah 6:12; compare 3:8).

Zechariah 6:10

Heldai, Tobijah, and Jedaiah were messengers chosen by Jews in Babylon to deliver donations for the temple building fund.

Zechariah 6:11

This crown likely consisted of two metal bands, one gold and one silver. Each band symbolized one of Jeshua's roles as king and priest.

Zechariah 6:12–13

- The Branch is a title for the Messiah (see Zechariah 3:8), whom Jeshua represents.
- build the temple of the LORD: Jeshua the high priest helped build the temple in Jerusalem (Ezra 3:1–2, 8–9; 5:2). Similarly, Jesus the Messiah would build the eternal heavenly temple through his death, burial, and resurrection (John 2:19–22; 4:23–24; Ephesians 2:19–22; Hebrews 8:1–2).
- The Messiah would rule as king, a role linked to David and the tribe of Judah (2 Samuel 7:12–16).

- He will be a priest on His throne: The Messiah's priestly role is linked to Aaron and the tribe of Levi (Exodus 29:44).
- Jeshua's crown represents his two roles. Melchizedek also had the dual roles of priest and king (Genesis 14:17–20), as does the Messiah (Psalm 110:4; Hebrews 7:1–3, 15–17).

Zechariah 6:14

- The symbolic crown, which united kingship and priesthood, was placed in the temple as a memorial to the gold and silver donors. It also served as a permanent reminder of Jeshua's coronation as priest-king and helped priests teach about this new development.
- Josiah received honor for arranging the meeting between Zechariah and the three former exiles.

Zechariah 6:15

Jews exiled in Babylon and other distant lands helped rebuild the temple. Because of this, all Israel could see the temple as belonging to them.

Zechariah 7:1

In the fourth year of King Darius: The two sermons in Zechariah 7–8 occurred almost two years after the visions in Zechariah 1–6.

Zechariah 7:1–14

Representatives from Bethel asked Zechariah a practical question (Zechariah 7:2–3). Although he answered it later (Zechariah 8:18–19), he first asked rhetorical questions about the people's selfish motives (7:5–6). Zechariah then explained God's expectations for Israel (Zechariah 7:8–10; see Jeremiah 22:3) and described what happened to those who disobeyed before (Zechariah 7:11–14).

Zechariah 7:1–8.23

These sermons provide a transition between the visions of the present (chapters 1–6) and those of the near future (chapters 9–11) and the more distant future (chapters 12–14).

Chapter 7 talks about fasting due to past disasters. Chapter 8 focuses on feasting for future blessings.

Zechariah 7:2

to plead before the LORD (literally to soften the face of the Lord): They asked God to grant a request or decide on a matter. They likely offered a sacrifice or offering with their request.

Zechariah 7:3

The group from Bethel asked a practical question about the process.

Zechariah 7:4–7

Instead of answering immediately, Zechariah challenged his listeners about their selfish motives and hypocrisy. The key issue was whether their true desire was to please God and follow his will. If not, fasting did not matter.

Zechariah 7:5

- Jeremiah said that 70 years of exile in Babylon (see Jeremiah 25:11–12; 29:10) would compensate for the Sabbath years of rest that the land missed for nearly 500 years (2 Chronicles 36:21; see Exodus 23:10–11; Leviticus 26:34–35).
- The summer fast mourned the destruction of Solomon's temple (Zechariah 7:3), while the early autumn fast either marked the assassination of Gedaliah, governor of Judah (see 2 Kings 25:22–25; Jeremiah 41:1–3), or it was the day of atonement (Leviticus 23:26–32).

Zechariah 7:7

Are these not the words: For example, see Isaiah 1:11–20; 58:3–7.

Zechariah 7:10

Widows, orphans, foreigners, and the poor often lacked the legal protection that the average citizen had (compare Deuteronomy 24:14, 17–18). Fasting and social justice should work together (see Isaiah 58:6–7).

Zechariah 7:11

- they refused to pay attention: They ignored God's commands (see Jeremiah 11:10).
- turned a stubborn shoulder: This phrase shows their proud stubbornness (see Nehemiah 9:29).
- Putting their fingers in their ears shows they were fully responsible for their stubbornness (compare Isaiah 6:10). The same expression describes Pharaoh when he became stubborn ("hardened his heart") against God and refused to release the Hebrews (Exodus 8:32).

Zechariah 7:12

- To make your heart like flint is to resist God's will (see Jeremiah 17:1; compare Ezekiel 3:9).
- The law (torah in Hebrew) refers to God's laws and commands as taught and explained by the prophets.

Zechariah 7:14

- I scattered them with a whirlwind: God scattered the Hebrew people among many nations. This scattering was one of the curses for breaking the Mosaic covenant (the agreement God made with Israel at Mount Sinai, Deuteronomy 28:36–37, 64).
- The pleasant land was the land of God's covenant promise (Psalm 106:24; Jeremiah 3:19).
- Their land became desolate because of God's judgment. The land was ruined because the people were unfaithful to the covenant and worshiped other gods (Jeremiah 12:10).

Zechariah 8:1–23

This part of Zechariah's sermons links to the previous section through fasting and the ethical demands of a covenant with the Lord (Zechariah 7:8–10; 8:16–17). Questions about fasting in 7:2–7 are answered in 8:18–19. The tone and message shift from warning and judgment to encouragement and renewal. Fasting will change to feasting (Zechariah 8:19).

Zechariah 8:2

Zeal (or passion or jealousy) is a key part of how the Old Testament describes God (see also Zechariah 1:14). God's zeal shows that he is personal and deeply involved, not an impersonal force of nature.

God is zealous for his word and for the people of his covenant. Because of this zeal, God judges sin, restores those who repent, and rewards those who pursue righteousness.

Zechariah 8:3

- I will ... dwell in Jerusalem: After the exile in Babylon, the people hoped the Lord would return to live among them (see Zechariah 1:16–17; Haggai 2:4–7; compare Ezekiel 48:35).
- I will return: God would come back to Jerusalem not only because the temple was rebuilt but also because the Hebrew community was purified (Zechariah 3).
- Isaiah compared Jerusalem to a faithful woman who became unfaithful (Isaiah 1:21). Zechariah shared Isaiah's vision of Jerusalem becoming the City of Truth again ("the Faithful City" in Isaiah 1:26).

Zechariah 8:4–5

The images of elderly men and women walking, along with boys and girls playing in the streets, show that families are returning to the once devastated city of Jerusalem. God's presence returning to his rebuilt temple will bring peace and safety to the city's people (see Jeremiah 33:10–11).

Zechariah 8:6

The Old Testament presents God as able to do what humans cannot do. God performs acts that are beyond human power because he created the heavens and the earth. Nothing is beyond God's ability or power (Genesis 18:14; Jeremiah 32:17, 27; see also Matthew 19:26).

Zechariah 8:7

from the land of the east and from the land of the west: This phrase means "from all the places where the Hebrew people had been scattered." It refers to the many regions where they lived after being forced out of their land (compare Isaiah 43:5–6).

Zechariah 8:8

they will be My people, and I will be their ... God: This phrase shows the close bond between Israel and God in their covenant relationship (see Exodus 19:5–6; Jeremiah 30:22; 31:33; Ezekiel 34:30–31; Hosea 2:23).

Zechariah 8:9

the foundations were laid: This refers to Zerubbabel's and Jeshua's first efforts to rebuild the temple in 536 BC (Ezra 3:8–13). They quickly abandoned the temple reconstruction project. It did not resume until the prophets Haggai and Zechariah encouraged it 16 years later (Ezra 5:1–2; Haggai 1:1).

Zechariah 8:9–13

This section shows how Jerusalem's situation improved when they rebuilt the temple (see 2 Chronicles 15:3–7). The call to be strong (Zechariah 8:9, 13) serves as an inclusio (a rhetorical device that begins and ends a section with a similar refrain) for the section.

Zechariah 8:10

the enemy: The neighboring peoples opposed rebuilding the temple (Ezra 4). Later, enemies opposed Nehemiah's rebuilding of Jerusalem's wall (Nehemiah 4).

Zechariah 8:12

- Peace (shalom in Hebrew) is an important theme in Zechariah's message (Zechariah 8:10, 12, 16, 19). God's presence in the rebuilt temple would bring peace to Judah (see Haggai 2:6–9). Zechariah uses the farming cycle to show God's blessing (see

Haggai 2:18–19), which would end the drought that Haggai described (Haggai 1:10).
- The small group of people who returned to Judah after the exile was called the remnant. In the Bible's teaching, the remnant connects God's judgment with his promise to restore his people (see Haggai 1:12, 14).

Zechariah 8:14–15

resolved: Repeating this word emphasizes God's control in judging Israel's sin and later blessing them.

Zechariah 8:16

- God expects his people to act with honesty and fairness (see Ephesians 4:25).
- your gates: Legal proceedings took place at the city or temple gates (see Deuteronomy 21:19; 25:7).

Zechariah 8:17

- During Zechariah's time, the people of Judah committed the same sins that led to the exile in Babylon. This behavior threatened God's plans for their restoration (see Zechariah 7:8–10; 8:16).
- I hate all these things: God hates evil (Psalm 5:5; Proverbs 6:16–19) because of his complete holiness (Psalms 5:4; 15:1; 24:3).

Zechariah 8:19

- Here, the Lord gives a clear answer to the question asked by the messengers from Bethel (Zechariah 7:2–3).
- The early summer fast remembered when Jerusalem's walls were breached (2 Kings 25:3–4; Jeremiah 52:6–7). The midsummer fast mourned the burning of Solomon's temple (2 Kings 25:8–10; Jeremiah 52:12–14). The autumn fast marked the assassination of Gedaliah, the governor of Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:22–25; Jeremiah 41:1–3) or the day of atonement (Leviticus 23:26–32). The winter fast recalled the start of the siege of Jerusalem (2 Kings 25:1; Jeremiah 52:4).
- The fasts will become feasts when God restores Israel and shows His glory to the nations (Isaiah 65:18–19).

Zechariah 8:23

God is with you: God's presence brings back the ideal relationship between God and people (Genesis 3:8; Exodus 24:9–11; 25:8; Isaiah 7:14; 57:15; Ezekiel 43:7; John 1:14).

Zechariah 9:1

- Aram was a city-state located on Israel's northern border, along the trade route linking Mesopotamia to the Mediterranean coast. Aram was sometimes an ally and sometimes an enemy of Israel and Judah.
- Damascus, the capital of Aram, marked the northern boundary of the ideal Hebrew state (Ezekiel 47:16–18).

Zechariah 9:1–8

This message reassured the Judeans that they should not fear their three main neighbors:

- Syria (Aram),
- the Phoenicians (Tyre and Sidon), and
- the Philistines.

These neighbors were rivals of Judah and often tried to gain commercial and territorial advantages. God said their efforts would fail.

Zechariah 9:1–11.17

This is the burden of the word: This is the superscription (introductory heading) for the entire section. It includes the term message (or oracle, burden), which is a prophetic statement of judgment. Using this word gives the message divine authority. These prophecies may relate to events between Zechariah's time and the coming of Christ.

Zechariah 9:1–14.21

The second part of Zechariah differs from the first in several ways. Zechariah 9–14 has an apocalyptic style (a style that uses symbolic language to describe God's future actions). It combines unclear references to past events with visions that look ahead to the future.

These messages alternate between warnings of judgment on other nations and promises of rescue for Israel. This section does not name Zechariah directly. Instead, it presents God speaking in his own voice. Most scholars think these messages come from a later time in Zechariah's ministry.

Zechariah 9:2

- Hamath was a fortress city on a southern trade route from Asia Minor. It marked the northern boundary of Israel (see Numbers 13:21; Joshua 13:5).
- The twin port cities of Tyre and Sidon were independent Phoenician kingdoms on the Mediterranean coast north of Israel (modern-day Lebanon). They often appear together in biblical texts (for example, Ezra 3:7; Joel 3:4; Luke 10:13–14). These cities were famous for their maritime trade wealth. However, Old

Testament prophets criticized their pride and harsh policies and predicted their destruction (Isaiah 23; Ezekiel 26:3–14; Amos 1:9–10).

Zechariah 9:3–4

The term fortress (Hebrew matsor) is a play on words with the name of the city of Tyre (Hebrew tsor). This famous island fortress (Isaiah 23:4; Ezekiel 26:5) was captured and destroyed by Alexander the Great in 332 BC.

Zechariah 9:5–6

Ashkelon ... Gaza ... Ekron ... Ashdod: These Philistine cities are on Israel's coastal plain. David defeated them (2 Samuel 5:17–25), but they later regained some independence. The prophets Amos and Zephaniah predicted similar judgments against these four cities (Amos 1:6–8; Zephaniah 2:4–7).

Zechariah 9:6

mixed race: This Hebrew word appears elsewhere only in Deuteronomy 23:2, where it refers to children born outside of marriage. Zechariah uses it to indicate that the Philistines will eventually lose their political and social identity.

Zechariah 9:7

- blood: The Philistines ate meat with blood, which was considered ceremonially unclean (see Genesis 9:4; Leviticus 3:17; Acts 15:20).
- Abominations refer to eating unclean foods (see Leviticus 11:2–23).
- they too will become a remnant for our God: This predicts Philip's work in the Philistine coastal cities (see Acts 8:40).
- The Jebusites were a Canaanite group (see Genesis 10:16; 1 Chronicles 1:14) living near Jerusalem. The city of Jebus (Jerusalem) was attacked and burned during the time of the judges (see Judges 1:8). David later recaptured it and made it his capital (see 2 Samuel 5:6–10). The Jebusites joined the Israelites through intermarriage during David's reign (see 2 Samuel 5:13).

Zechariah 9:9

- your king: This refers to a future king from David's line, earlier described as the Branch (Zechariah 3:8; 6:12–13).
- The donkey was a humble animal. Riding on a donkey showed that the rider came in peace (see Matthew 21:5; John 12:15).

Zechariah 9:9–17

The second message of Zechariah's first oracle (Zechariah 9–11) contrasts war and peace, themes that have shaped human history. Judah's future deliverer-king will win in battle, yet remain righteous and humble (Zechariah 9:9). He will bring peace to all nations during his universal reign (Zechariah 9:10).

Zechariah 9:10

- Here, Israel contrasts with Judah, the southern kingdom. The pairing of Israel and Jerusalem represents a reunited Israel and the reclaiming of the covenant land.
- The kingdoms of Assyria, Babylonia, Persia, and Israel were created through military conquest. In contrast, the kingdom of the Messiah will dismantle war machinery and eliminate all weapons (see Isaiah 2:4; 9:5; Micah 5:10–11; Joel 3:10).
- The Euphrates River marked the northern border of the promised land (Genesis 15:18).
- the ends of the earth: The righteous king will bring universal peace.

Zechariah 9:11

- The covenant sealed with blood most likely refers to the sacrifice involving blood that confirmed the Mosaic covenant (the agreement God made with Israel at Mount Sinai, Exodus 24:8).
- The prisoners were Jews still living as exiles in Mesopotamia after the exile in Babylon. The Jews who stayed in Persia and Babylon were spiritual exiles because they lived outside the promised land of spiritual blessing and rest (see Deuteronomy 12:10). One of the Messiah's key roles would be to free prisoners (Isaiah 61:1; Luke 4:17–22; Romans 7:6; Ephesians 4:8).

Zechariah 9:12

Return to your stronghold: This calls for the Jews still in Babylon to go back to Judah.

Zechariah 9:13

In Zechariah's time, the Persian Empire and the Greeks were competing for power. Looking ahead, God promised to judge the Greeks, who may also represent all Gentile nations.

Zechariah may be pointing to the vision recorded in the book of Daniel, where Greece appears as a future ruling power (Daniel 8:21–22).

Zechariah 9:14

- Zechariah uses the image of a winged sun disk, which artists showed as hovering protectively over the Persian king. The Lord will protect Israel, lead them in battle, and demonstrate his power.
- The ram's horn calls people together (Numbers 10:2–3, 7–10; Isaiah 27:13) and announces God's presence and power (Exodus 19:19; 20:18).
- The whirlwind shows God as a warrior with great power and quickness (Psalm 77:18; Isaiah 21:1; 29:6; 66:15). References to lightning remind us of Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:16) and God's covenant promises to Israel.

Zechariah 9:15

- slingstones: In ancient battles, large stones were thrown at defenders on city walls and launched at people inside. The Maccabees' victory over the Hellenistic Seleucids in the 100s BC might have partly fulfilled Zechariah's prophecy of Israel defeating the Greeks (see 1 Maccabees 3:16–24; 4:6–16; 7:40–50).
- they will be filled ... drenched: When the Lord sends his armies against the Greeks, there will be a lot of bloodshed.
- like sprinkling bowls: Ceremonial sprinkling bowls filled with animal blood were used in sacrifice rituals. This image suggests that defeating the Lord's enemies is, in some way, an offering to him (see Exodus 24:6; Leviticus 1:5; 16:18).

Zechariah 9:16

- On that day: See study note on Zechariah 3:10.
- The Old Testament prophets described the Messiah as both a king and a faithful shepherd (see Ezekiel 34:12, 16, 23; 37:24; John 10:1; Hebrews 13:20; 1 Peter 5:4).

Zechariah 9:17

Grain ... new wine: Large harvests of grain and wine showed that God was blessing his people in visible, everyday ways. Agricultural success was a clear sign of God's favor (see Joel 2:19; Amos 9:13; compare Haggai 1:11).

Zechariah 10:1

Rain was a sign of divine blessing (see Joel 2:23). The Lord provided the rain, but Israel's leaders made the people trust false gods instead.

Zechariah 10:1–3

This rebuke targets false shepherds, human leaders who use their people for their own benefit instead of caring for them.

Zechariah 10:1–11.3

God will strengthen his people with his power and restore them because of his compassion (Zechariah 10:6, 12). The passage mentions shepherds several times (Zechariah 10:2–3; 11:3). These references prepare the reader for the next section, which uses an allegory (a symbolic story) about good and evil shepherds (11:4–17).

Zechariah 10:2

idols: This might refer to ancestor statues used in ceremonies to summon the spirits of the dead. Consulting with the dead was common in the ancient world, but God's law forbade it for the Hebrews (see Leviticus 20:27; Deuteronomy 18:10–11).

Zechariah 10:3

- My anger burns: Israel often faces this divine wrath due to disobedience to covenant rules or falling into idol worship (see Exodus 22:22–24; Deuteronomy 6:14–15; Joshua 7:1; Judges 2:20; Hebrews 10:31).
- the leaders (or these male goats): This is a metaphor for princes, since male goats usually lead goat herds.

Zechariah 10:4

- A cornerstone is the first foundation stone that supports a building's structure (see Job 38:6; Psalm 118:22; Isaiah 28:16; Ephesians 2:20).
- Just as a tent peg secures a tent to the ground, Judah will provide future leaders to stabilize the Hebrew nation.
- Many see the cornerstone, tent peg, and bow for battle as titles for the Messiah (compare Isaiah 22:20–23; Zechariah 9:13).

Zechariah 10:4–12

A true shepherd will come. God promises a faithful leader who will care for his people and guide them rightly.

Zechariah 10:6

- save: This Hebrew word is also used for the escape from Egypt (see Exodus 14:30). Salvation and victory come from God (Psalm 3:8; Isaiah 63:1).

- God saves and restores his people, Israel, because of his compassion (see Exodus 33:19; Psalms 103:13; 111:4; Lamentations 3:32).

Zechariah 10:8

- I will whistle for them: In biblical times, shepherds guided their flocks by whistling or playing pipes (see Judges 5:16).
- Redeemed can also mean "ransomed," which is buying slaves out of their servitude or indentured status (see Deuteronomy 15:15; 24:18).
- Numerous as they once were: The growth of the Hebrew people was one of God's promises to Abraham (Genesis 12:1–3; 22:17; 32:12).

Zechariah 10:10

- The Lord had previously called the armies of Egypt and Assyria to attack King Ahaz of Judah because he did not believe (Isaiah 7:18). These two nations symbolized the slavery and exile the Hebrews faced.
- Gilead is a fertile area east of the Jordan River and south of the Sea of Galilee. It is good for growing grain and raising animals. The tribes of Manasseh and Gad settled there.
- Lebanon sometimes marked the northern boundary of the promised land (see Deuteronomy 11:24; Joshua 1:4). God would restore and resettle the Hebrews so completely that even the outer areas of Israelite land would be full of people.

Zechariah 10:11

When the Hebrews returned to Israel from exile in Babylon, they had to cross the Euphrates River. This journey is similar to their exodus from Egypt (see Isaiah 43:2–6, 16–17).

Zechariah 10:12

This verse repeats the earlier promise that God will strengthen his people (Zechariah 10:6; see Isaiah 41:8–10; compare Psalms 18:1; 22:19; 28:8; 29:11).

Zechariah 11:1

Lebanon, with its snow-covered mountains and fertile valleys, was a symbol of strength and fertility.

Zechariah 11:1–3

This taunt song against Lebanon and Bashan wraps up the earlier message about Israel's deliverance and restoration (Zechariah 10:1–12). It might also lead into the next message about good and bad shepherds (Zechariah 11:4–17).

Zechariah 11:2

Lebanon and Bashan had excellent forests. These places are often mentioned together (Isaiah 2:13; Jeremiah 22:20–22; Ezekiel 27:5–6) to represent nations that God would judge. This judgment would occur when God regathers and restores the people of Israel (see Zechariah 10:11).

Zechariah 11:3

Shepherds and lions symbolically represent the leaders of Lebanon and Bashan. They mourn the loss of their forested slopes, pride, and livelihood (see Zechariah 11:1–2).

Zechariah 11:4

- The people of Israel are God's flock (see Isaiah 40:11; Micah 5:4). Sheep are helpless, so they need careful shepherding.
- marked for slaughter: Like sheep fattened for butchering, people are treated as disposable goods in a corrupt economy.

Zechariah 11:4–17

The Hebrew leaders are compared to shepherds in the last three messages (Zechariah 9:9–11:17) of Zechariah's first oracle (Zechariah 9–11). This message uses allegory and symbolic actions by Zechariah to show the wickedness of Israel's leaders. The prophet acts out a story of a "good shepherd" chosen by God to guide and unite the people. However, the people reject this shepherd and the promise of protection from other nations (Zechariah 11:10) and unity between Judah and Israel (11:14). Zechariah's symbolic actions point ahead to the work of Jesus the Messiah. His ministry fulfills this image as the Good Shepherd (see John 10:1–21).

Zechariah 11:5

- The sheep (the Hebrew people) were being sold as slaves to foreign powers, foreign allies, or local slave traders (see Amos 2:6).
- The sellers were the leaders, who cared more about getting rich than the well-being of the people.

Zechariah 11:7

- Shepherd's staffs represent leadership and authority.
- Favor: This staff symbolized God's choice of Israel as his people (see Genesis 12:1–3) and the promise of a leader like King David (see 2 Samuel 7:12–16).

- Union: Ezekiel's staff (Ezekiel 37:16–17) represented the unity of the Hebrew tribes as a single nation during King David's reign (2 Samuel 5:1–3).

Zechariah 11:8

The mysterious historical mention of three evil shepherds has led to over 40 attempts to identify them. None of these explanations is effective. Three represents completeness. God appoints good shepherds to replace evil ones for the well-being of his people.

Zechariah 11:9

devour one another's flesh: This might refer literally to cannibalism (people eating human flesh) caused by famine during the siege of Jerusalem in 588–586 BC (see Lamentations 4:10) and later in AD 70 (see Josephus, War 7.4.4). The expression may also be a metaphor for different types of exploitation and oppression (see Micah 3:3; Galatians 5:15).

Zechariah 11:10

- Unlike Ezekiel, who acted out the reunification of the Hebrew kingdoms, Zechariah acted out their division (Ezekiel 37:15–19). Zechariah showed this division by cutting two staffs in half (see also Zechariah 11:14). Cutting the staffs symbolized the broken covenant between God and his people (Zechariah 11:11) and the broken unity between the kingdoms of Judah and Israel (11:14).
- A covenant between the Lord and all nations is otherwise unknown. Zechariah might have been announcing the end of the covenant that bound Israel to God as his people (compare Hosea 1:6–9; see study note on Zechariah 13:9).

Zechariah 11:12

Thirty pieces of silver was the price of a slave (see Exodus 21:32). In the story, the silver was payment for the shepherd's dismissal (Zechariah 11:9). The gospel writers see this passage fulfilled when Judas betrays Jesus for 30 silver coins (see Matthew 26:15; 27:9–10).

Zechariah 11:13

- to the potter: Some scholars think a professional group of potters might have been minor temple officials because of the constant need for sacred vessels (see Leviticus 6:28). Others, noting the similarity between potter (Hebrew yotser) and treasury (ʾotsar), follow the Syriac version, which reads into the treasury (see Matthew 27:6, 10; compare Jeremiah 32:6–9). The Greek Old Testament translates this sentence as "throw it into the furnace," suggesting the silver was melted down and recast into a silver vessel for temple rituals.
- Thirty coins (or pieces of silver) was a large sum of money, nearly two years' wages for the average worker.

Zechariah 11:15

The worthless shepherd represents corrupt leaders, in contrast to the good shepherd (compare Ezekiel 34:7–16).

Zechariah 11:16

tear off their hooves: This is a Hebrew saying. It means searching greedily for the last bit of meat on an animal carcass (see Micah 3:3).

Zechariah 11:17

This oracle of woe is a poetic curse against the worthless shepherd for abandoning the flock. The arm and right eye represent the physical and mental abilities of the shepherd. The injured arm and blinded eye leave the worthless shepherd without strength or vision. These wounds bring his selfish and harmful rule to an end.

Zechariah 12:1–14.21

The theme of Jerusalem versus the nations connects the four messages in Zechariah's second oracle. The nations gather against Jerusalem at both the start (Zechariah 12:1–9) and the end (14:1–15) of the oracle. The repeated phrase on that day points to the future day of the Lord.

This oracle shows both judgment and blessing for Jerusalem. The main focus is the cleansing of the people of Israel (Zechariah 13:1), ending with God's universal kingdom (14:16–21). These future visions encouraged the Judeans of Zechariah's time to stay faithful despite feeling unimportant and helpless.

Zechariah 12:2

cup of drunkeness: The cup of alcoholic drink is a metaphor for God's judgment (Isaiah 51:17; Jeremiah 25:15; Habakkuk 2:16; Matthew 26:39, 42; Revelation 14:10; 16:1). Jerusalem would play a key role in God's judgment on nearby nations.

Zechariah 12:3

Jerusalem will be like a heavy stone that no one can move. Anyone who tries to conquer or control the city will be injured by it. This is because the Lord founded

Jerusalem and loves it more than any other city in Israel (Psalm 87:1–2).

In the book of Zechariah, stone imagery is often connected to the temple. These stones point to God's work of building, restoring, and protecting his holy place (Zechariah 3:9; 4:7; 10:4).

Zechariah 12:4

- Madness, blindness, and panic were some of the curses threatened against Israel for breaking the covenant (Deuteronomy 28:28). On the day of the Lord, these curses will instead affect Israel's enemies (see 2 Kings 7:6–7).
- keep a watchful eye (literally open my eyes): God's open eyes symbolize divine help for those in great need (see Genesis 16:13–14; 21:19–21).

Zechariah 12:5

LORD of Hosts: This title emphasizes God's unstoppable power (see study note on Zechariah 1:3). The repeated use of this title in Zechariah's second oracle (Zechariah 12–14) assured his audience that God would definitely fulfill the promises about Judah's victory (12:7).

Zechariah 12:6

firepot: People used bronze or gold firepans to carry hot coals to and from the sacrificial altars of the tabernacle and the temple (Exodus 27:3; 1 Kings 7:50). God would place Israel among the nations like a burning firepan to destroy or purify them.

Zechariah 12:8

Here, the angel of the LORD is identified with God himself. He is shown as a divine warrior who rescues and protects his people (see Zechariah 1:11; 3:1; Exodus 14:19; 15:3; Isaiah 59:15–20; 63:1–6). God will give power to the weak.

Zechariah 12:10

- pour out: This term describes God pouring out the spirit of prophecy on Israel and all people on the day of the Lord (compare Ezekiel 39:28–29; Joel 2:28–29) and God's judgment on the wicked (Lamentations 2:4; Hosea 5:10; Zephaniah 3:8).
- spirit of grace: God's undeserved and unsolicited favor encourages people to seek Him through humble and repentant prayer (see Psalm 86:15–16).
- the One they have pierced: The New Testament views the piercing of God as a reference to the piercing of the Messiah, Jesus of Nazareth (John 19:34–37; Revelation 1:7).

Zechariah 12:11

- The name Hadad-rimmon combines the names of two Syrian gods: the storm god Hadad and the thunder god Rimmon. People mourned greatly for these gods, similar to the weeping for Tammuz, a ceremony in Mesopotamian fertility cults.
- Joshua captured Megiddo (Joshua 12:21), a major city on the southwest edge of the Jezreel Valley. It was given to the tribe of Manasseh (Joshua 17:11).

Megiddo controlled a key pass on the main highway from Egypt to Mesopotamia, making it very important strategically. It was a district capital during King Solomon's reign (1 Kings 4:12).
King Josiah was fatally wounded in a battle against Pharaoh Neco and the Egyptians on the plain of Megiddo (2 Chronicles 35:22–23). The mountain of Megiddo is the site of the great battle described in Revelation 16:16.

Zechariah 12:12–14

- the clan of the house of David ... Nathan ... Levi ... Shimei: Zechariah might be referring to the royal families (David and his son Nathan; see 1 Chronicles 14:4) and the priestly families (Levi and his grandson Shimei; see Numbers 3:16–18; 1 Chronicles 6:16–17). Alternatively, the four families might represent the four main leadership roles in Old Testament times:
- the king (David, 1 Samuel 16:1–13),
- the prophet (Nathan, 2 Samuel 7:2),
- the priest (Levi, Deuteronomy 33:8–11), and
- the tribal leader (Shimei, 1 Kings 1:8; 4:18).

The first interpretation aligns with Zechariah's focus on the Branch that will be both king and priest (see Zechariah 6:12–13).

- all the remaining clans: This separation shows the depth and completeness of Israel's mourning.

Zechariah 13:1

- A fountain is a source of pure, flowing water used for cleansing and purification (see Zechariah 14:8; John 4:14; Revelation 22:1–2).
- God will cleanse Israel, including its leaders (represented by the family line of kings descended from David) and all the people of Judah and Israel (represented by the people of Jerusalem, the nation's spiritual center).
- to cleanse them: This cleansing, symbolized by the ceremonial washings in Old Testament worship (see Exodus 30:17–21), was provided in the new covenant as promised by Jeremiah (Jeremiah 31:34) and Ezekiel (Ezekiel 36:25; see Hebrews 10:1–22).

- sin and impurity: The Hebrews would experience complete moral and spiritual cleansing because of their sorrow over their sin (Zechariah 12:10–14).

Zechariah 13:1–6

The second message (Zechariah 13:126) of the second oracle (Zechariah 12–14) focuses on cleansing from sin.

Zechariah 13:2

- By cleansing Israel, God would remove their past habit of idol worship, giving them a new heart to worship only God (Jeremiah 31:33; 32:38–40; Ezekiel 36:25–28).
- In biblical times, a person's name represented their existence. When people forget the names of idols, the idols no longer exist.
- False prophets misrepresented God by creating fake divine messages or speaking in the name of other gods (Deuteronomy 13:5–11; 18:17–22). They led Israel away from God by promoting idol worship (Jeremiah 23:13, 25) and would continue to do so (see Nehemiah 6:12–14; Mark 13:22; 2 Peter 2:1; 1 John 4:1–3) until the day of the Lord.

Zechariah 13:3

You shall not remain alive: According to God's law, a false prophet must be executed (Deuteronomy 13:5, 10; 18:20). The Israelites had tolerated false prophets and killed the Lord's true prophets. In the future, this situation would change.

Zechariah 13:4

- ashamed of his vision: In the Old Testament, people often called a prophet a visionary "seer" (see 1 Samuel 9:9–19; 2 Kings 17:13) because they received divine messages in dreams or night visions (for example, Zechariah 1:7–6:15).
- hairy cloak: Old Testament Hebrew prophets wore a rough cloak made of camel or goat hair (see 2 Kings 1:8; Matthew 3:4).

Zechariah 13:4–6

God will completely cleanse his people from their sin and impurity. This cleansing will create such fear that false prophets will hide who they really are. They will deny their identity and lie about what they do, especially if their actions resemble those of prophets from idolatrous cults (groups that worship false gods).

Zechariah 13:5

I work the land: This statement may be a deliberate echo of Amos 7:14. In that passage, Amos says he is not a prophet by profession but a farmer whom the Lord called to speak his message.

Zechariah 13:6

wounds on your chest?: These wounds may be cuts or bruises. Some ecstatic prophets (prophets who worked themselves into a religious frenzy), especially in Canaanite worship, injured themselves during ceremonies (see 1 Kings 18:28).

When questioned, false prophets would try to explain the wounds away. They might claim, "I was wounded at my friends' house," to hide their former practices.

Zechariah 13:7

- The sword is described as a warrior called to awaken for battle, emphasizing its role as God's servant and a tool of death (see Isaiah 31:8; 34:6; 66:16).
- My shepherd represents the Messiah, the future leader of Israel (see Ezekiel 34:23; 37:24).
- My partner shows the shepherd's equality with God (see Matthew 26:31; Mark 14:27).

Zechariah 13:7–9

This message talks about a future day when God's chosen leader of Israel will be harmed, causing the people of Israel to scatter. Some of the nation will face divine judgment, while others will experience spiritual renewal. This will fulfill Zechariah's vision of God being with his people again (see Zechariah 1:16; 2:5, 10–11; 8:3, 23). The gospel writers connect parts of this passage (Zechariah 13:7) to the scattering of the disciples of Jesus when he was arrested, tried, and executed by the Romans (see Matthew 26:31, 56).

Zechariah 13:8

two-thirds ... a third: The divine judgment would be catastrophic. However, God would save a small group and forgive their sin (see Isaiah 65:9; Jeremiah 50:20; Ezekiel 5:2–12; Revelation 9:15–18).

Zechariah 13:9

- Fire is a metaphor for God's judgment (see Isaiah 66:15; Jeremiah 4:4; Ezekiel 36:5; Amos 5:6). God's fire can destroy the wicked or, as in this context, test and purify the righteous.
- Refine them ... like gold: God acts as a divine metallurgist, using fire to remove impurities from metal (Isaiah 1:25; Malachi 3:2–3).
- They are my people ... The LORD is our God: These declarations of loyalty by God and Israel restore their broken covenant relationship (Zechariah 11:10,

14; see Exodus 19:5; Jeremiah 30:22; 31:33; Hosea 2:23).

Zechariah 14:1

The day of the Lord will bring judgment and deliverance. On that day, God will reverse many people's situations, lifting some up and bringing others low (see Amos 5:18; compare Matthew 19:28–30; Luke 13:23–30).

Zechariah 14:1–21

Zechariah ends with visions of judgment, salvation, and God's universal kingdom. In the future, Israel will face a siege and near destruction, but the Lord will intervene to save his people (Zechariah 14:3–4) and punish their enemies with a severe plague (14:12). Israel will be restored as God's people, and Jerusalem will become the center of civilization (Zechariah 14:16–17). God's rule will extend over the entire earth (Zechariah 14:9), and the natural world will change (14:6–10). God's holiness will be the defining feature of his rule over the earth (Zechariah 14:20–21).

Zechariah's message calls God's people to hope in the King of Israel, who has full power and authority.

Zechariah 14:2

The rest refers to the remaining people of Israel who survived when Jerusalem was attacked (see Zechariah 13:8).

Zechariah 14:3

as He fights in the day of battle: One example is the exodus from Egypt (Exodus 14–15; see Isaiah 42:13).

Zechariah 14:4

- Jesus went up into heaven from the Mount of Olives. After this, angels told the disciples of Jesus that he would return in the same way they had seen him go (Acts 1:11–12).
- The prophet Zechariah describes an earthquake that will split the Mount of Olives in two. This will create a valley running east and west. The valley will give the Hebrews an escape route when the nations attack Jerusalem (Zechariah 14:5). Many Christians connect this event with the return of Jesus at the end of the age (see Matthew 24; Revelation 6:12; 11:13; 16:18).

Zechariah 14:5

- Some scholars believe Azal (Hebrew 'atsal) is a district on the northeast side of Jerusalem, where Azel's descendants lived (1 Chronicles 8:37–39; 9:43–44). Others suggest changing the Hebrew to 'etsel, meaning "alongside" or "the side of it."
- The date of the earthquake during King Uzziah's time is unknown, but Amos started his ministry two years before it (Amos 1:1).
- The holy ones are likely the many angels who worship God and serve as his army (see Psalm 89:5, 7).

Zechariah 14:7

a unique day: The day of the Lord will bring major changes to the world (see Isaiah 60:19–22; Revelation 21:22–25). This promise emphasizes that God created the sun and moon, and they are not eternal gods. Light does not come from them.

Zechariah 14:8

- The living waters from Jerusalem represent God's presence among his people (see Ezekiel 47:1–12; Joel 3:18; John 7:37–39; Revelation 22:1–2).
- half of it toward the Eastern Sea and the other half toward the Western Sea: These divine blessings will reach both east and west, flowing continuously. They will always bring healing (see Isaiah 30:23–26).

Zechariah 14:9

- the LORD will become King: Zechariah looks ahead to the final fulfillment of many psalms that celebrate the Lord as king (see Psalms 47–48, 93, 97–99).
- the LORD alone: This promise restates Israel's central confession of faith (Deuteronomy 6:4). It points to a future time when all idolatry (the worship of false gods) will completely end.

Zechariah 14:10

The towns of Geba and Rimmon mark the northern and southern borders of the district that includes Jerusalem.

Zechariah 14:12

As the divine judge, God punishes those who rebel against him with a sudden and deadly plague (see Exodus 9:14; Numbers 14:36–37; 2 Samuel 24:10–25; Jeremiah 14:11–12).

Zechariah 14:13

The day of the Lord will bring fear to God's enemies (Zechariah 12:4; see Isaiah 22:5).

Zechariah 14:14

- The day of the Lord involves a reversal: The wealth of the nations will be taken. This reverses the earlier

announcement that Jerusalem would be plundered (Zechariah 14:1).
- gold, silver, and apparel in great abundance: The Lord's temple will defeat the nations and receive all their treasures (Haggai 2:7–8).

Zechariah 14:16

- the nations ... will go up ... to worship the King: Another reversal will happen on the day of the Lord (compare Philippians 2:8–11).
- The annual Feast of Tabernacles marked the start of the fall harvest season. It commemorated Israel's time in the wilderness after leaving Egypt (see Exodus 23:14–19; Leviticus 23:33–43; Numbers 29:12–40; Deuteronomy 16:13–17). The festival gave the worshiping community a chance to thank God for his provision. It encouraged social concern for the disadvantaged and reliance on God as pilgrims in this world. Thanksgiving will define worship in the messianic era (see Isaiah 51:3; Jeremiah 33:11).

Zechariah 14:17

- go up to Jerusalem to worship the King: Jerusalem, with God's temple, is seen as the center of God's worldwide kingdom (Zechariah 8:20–22; see Isaiah 56:6–7; 66:19–23; Micah 4:1; Haggai 2:7; Revelation 21:1–2, 10–27).
- the rain: This was one of the curses God announced against Israel for breaking the covenant (see Deuteronomy 28:22–24). That curse also applied to all nations, as God's rule covers all people (compare Zechariah 10:1).

Zechariah 14:20

HOLY TO THE LORD: See study note on Zechariah 3:5. The Lord set apart the priesthood and the nation of Israel (Exodus 19:6; Leviticus 11:44–45). This identity will be complete in the messianic kingdom (Romans 11:16–17; Ephesians 1:4; 5:27; 1 Peter 1:15–16). The words on the harness bells and cooking pots show how widespread holiness will be then.

Zechariah 14:21

- every pot: In God's kingdom, even ordinary pots will become holy, like those used in temple rituals. This change will remove all Old Testament differences between sacred and ordinary items.
- Canaanites: People linked commercial activity with the Canaanites (see Hosea 12:7; Zephaniah 1:11). The term might mean idolaters or suggest that under God's rule, traditional ethnic boundaries will disappear. The passage may predict Jesus cleansing the Jerusalem temple, which leads to cleansing believers' hearts through the holy spirit (see John 2:13–16; 1 Corinthians 6:11; Titus 3:5).